

GMZ Landscaping Inc.

DESIGN · BUILD · MAINTENANCE

From the first call to the signed job, and what the price is at every step.

The twelve stages a design and build lead moves through, the seven a maintenance account moves through, and the one thing to say about money at each of them.

The whole pipeline exists for one reason. A landscape price gets accurate only as two things happen: somebody measures the property, and somebody chooses the materials. Until both are done, any single number is a guess wearing a suit. So GMZ sells the measuring and the choosing as their own small stages, and gives the client a different *kind* of number at each one. Nothing is withheld. The precision is simply earned in order.

INTERNAL · NOT FOR CLIENT DISTRIBUTION

PREPARED FOR

Xavier
Anyone answering the phone

DATED

17 August 2026
Re-read when a stage changes

BUILT FROM

The stage model in *process-proposal*,
the published answers in
src/content/faqs, and the intake pack

01 THE IDEA TO LEAD WITH

There are exactly three numbers, and they are not the same kind of thing

Most of the friction in this trade comes from one confusion: the client hears every number as a price, and only the third one is. Name which of the three you are handing over, every time.

The first number

A planning range

WHAT IT IS

A window for the work described, broken out by area of the property. Built from a walk, photos and rough dimensions.

WHAT IT IS NOT

A bid, an offer GMZ is bound to, or a number that can be held.

CALLED

Preliminary Budget and Scope Acknowledgment. It says so on its face.

WHY IT IS WIDE

Nothing is measured and nothing is chosen. It narrows in steps as both happen, and the loose parts get named: demolition, drainage, anything underground.

The second number

A design fee

WHAT IT IS

The price of the work that produces the third number. Ten to fifteen percent of the construction price, which is why the range has to exist first.

WHERE IN THE BAND

How many areas are in scope, how much grading and drainage there is to resolve, how much irrigation, whether anything needs outside review.

NOT CREDITED

It does not come off the construction price and it is not refunded. Say this on the first call, not at signing.

INCLUDES

Two rounds of revision. Beyond that is priced in writing first.

The third number

A fixed price

WHAT IT IS

A number the client can sign, built from a measured plan and selected materials. The first and only commitment about construction cost.

WHAT EARNS IT

The measured survey and the material decisions. Nothing else does.

HOW LONG IT HOLDS

To the date on the face of the bid, normally thirty days. Past it, material prices get re-checked and the changed line gets shown.

ITS SHORTEST PAGE

The exclusions. Named item by item rather than padded, because a padded number charges everybody for the unlucky ones.

THE ONE SENTENCE, IF YOU ONLY GET ONE

“The visit is free and it commits you to nothing. What comes out of it is a range to plan around. A price you can actually sign comes after we have measured the property and you have chosen the materials, because those two things move a landscape number more than anything else.”

Why the concept is paid now

It used to be given away. A free concept costs the person receiving it nothing, so it gets treated as worth nothing, and the pull is to produce it fast rather than properly. A small fee pays for real time, and separates the clients planning a project from the ones collecting drawings.

The ask also gets easier, not harder. *Buy a full design before you know what this costs* is a leap. *Buy a concept and a budget for a small fee, then decide* is a step.

The fourth case: somebody else drew it

A client arriving with an architect's or a designer's plan set skips stages 04 and 05 entirely, and **there is no design fee**, because GMZ is not doing the design. Walk the property, check the drawings against the ground, and say plainly where a plan does not match the site before pricing anything.

What is needed is the full set: plan, plant list, and any grading, drainage or construction details.

02 THE SHAPE OF IT

Twelve stages, four bands, and two places money changes hands before a contract

Each gate exists so the next stage is only run on work worth running it on. Read the four bands rather than the twelve stages: qualify, sell a small paid look, sell the measuring, build and hand over.

BAND A Qualify Costs GMZ time and fuel, deliberately. Nothing is charged and nothing firm is said.	01 Inquiry Every lead lands in one place on arrival, whoever took the call: name, town, scope, channel, date. No number of any kind. 02 Phone qualification Fifteen minutes: scope, budget band, timeline, who decides, where it is. The budget band is the gate. Decline or defer here, before the drive, not after it. 03 Site consultation Free, run off a checklist, and a working conversation rather than a sales call. Also where GMZ decides whether to take the project. Ends with an offer of the paid first phase, fee in writing first.
BAND B Sell the look First money in. Small enough to be an easy yes, real enough to filter.	04 Concept and planning budget Client pays: the concept phase fee. Two deliverables, a written concept and the planning range. Acknowledging the range commits the client to nothing; it exists so two people cannot remember the scope differently later.
BAND C Sell the measuring The band that earns a firm price. Everything before it is honest guesswork.	05 Design development Client pays: the design fee, ten to fifteen percent of construction. Second phase of the same agreement, entered only on approval of the concept. Measured survey and drawings. The clock starts at measuring, not at signing. 06 Bid presentation Plan and price presented together, in person, and the decision asked for in the room. Exclusions walked through out loud. Alternates on the big-ticket materials if the client wants to see the trade in dollars.
BAND D Build and hand over Payment follows visible work. The last of it waits for the punch list.	07 Construction agreement Client pays: the deposit, then a payment per completed phase. One compliant contract on every job above \$500. A start date is held by a signed contract, not by a conversation. 08 Pre-construction meeting Half an hour before the first truck: access, gate codes, hours, parking, pets, kids, who to call, what week one looks like. 09 Build One update a week, same day, with a photo: what changed, what is next, what needs a decision. Anything outside scope becomes a signed change order before it happens. 10 Substantial completion Written punch list, every job, both parties holding a copy. Ten business days to clear it. The job is complete when the list is, and the final payment is tied to that. 11 Closeout Plan copy, plant list, irrigation zone map and controller settings, care guide, the written warranty, and the maintenance proposal. 12 Follow-up A call at thirty days and again at six months. The cheapest referral and maintenance conversion in this document.

○ Stage runs, nothing charged ● Client pays here ● Gate: a decision is asked for

03 STAGE BY STAGE, FIRST HALF

Inquiry to bid: what exists, what it costs, what has to be true to move on

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT THE CLIENT WALKS AWAY WITH	WHAT THEY PAY	THE GATE TO THE NEXT STAGE
01 Inquiry	Lead recorded in one place on arrival, whatever channel it came in on.	A callback with an actual date attached to it.	Nothing	It is written down somewhere both Lili and Xavier can see.
02 Phone qualification	Fifteen minutes on scope, budget band, timeline, decision makers and location. The budget question is asked plainly and early.	An honest read on fit, in the towns served or not, and which kind of visit their job actually is.	Nothing	Budget band and described scope are in the same neighbourhood, and the property is servable. If not, say so on the call.
03 Site consultation	Property walked off a checklist: access, grade, drainage, what is growing, the narrowest gate, where water sits after rain.	A shared understanding of the work, and an offer of the paid first phase with its fee in writing.	Nothing. The visit is free and commits them to nothing.	GMZ wants the project and the client accepts the concept phase. Either party may stop here at no cost.
04 Concept and planning budget	A considered look at what the property could become, put on paper by somebody who stood on it, plus a range broken out by area.	A written concept and the Preliminary Budget and Scope Acknowledgment, which states on its face that it is not a bid.	Concept phase fee	The client acknowledges the scope and the range, and wants to keep going. This obligates them to nothing further.
05 Design development	Measured survey, then drawings: layout, planting plan, irrigation and drainage resolved, materials specified closely enough to price and build from.	A measured plan set for the property, and the firm construction number that only measured plans can produce. Two revision rounds included.	Design fee, 10 to 15% of construction	Presentation date met, or moved before it passes rather than after. Material selections settled.
06 Bid presentation	Plan and price presented together in person. Exclusions read out loud. Alternates priced on the identical scope where the client asked to compare material levels.	A fixed price they can sign, valid to the date on its face, normally thirty days.	Nothing new	A decision, asked for in the room. Not a package emailed and waited on.

The five items that stop a firm number

- 1 Client name and the property address
- 2 Which items are in scope, not their dimensions
- 3 Material tier on the big-ticket items, or two tiers to price
- 4 Access: what a truck and a small machine can reach, and the narrowest gate
- 5 Demolition and disposal: in, out, or the client is handling it

All five, or the estimate is a guess with a decimal point in it.

Three gates that cost real money if missed

- **Any signer aged sixty-five or over.** The cancellation right is five days, not three. It goes on every agreement in the job, not just the first one.
- **New landscape at or above 500 sq ft, or rehab at or above 2,500 sq ft, with a permit.** The water ordinance documentation is triggered.
- **A rebate in play.** Nothing gets torn out before the notice to proceed. Check the water supplier and the turf area first.

04 STAGE BY STAGE, SECOND HALF

Contract to follow-up: money follows work the client can stand and look at

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT THE CLIENT WALKS AWAY WITH	WHAT THEY PAY	THE GATE TO THE NEXT STAGE
07 Construction agreement	One compliant contract on every job above \$500, with milestone payments and the statutory deposit cap. Long-lead materials ordered the moment it is in.	A signed contract, a payment schedule tied to phases, and a start date that is now actually theirs.	Deposit: \$1,000 or 10% of contract, whichever is less	Signed, and the cancellation window run. Long-lead ordering, not crew availability, usually sets the earliest honest start.
08 Pre-construction meeting	Half an hour on site: access, gate codes, working hours, parking, pets, kids, who to call, and what week one looks like.	A named contact and no surprises on the first morning.	Nothing	Utility locate called in before any digging. Access confirmed against what the gate actually measures.
09 Build	Work runs in phases: site preparation and grading, hardscape, irrigation, planting. One written update a week, same day, with a photo.	A payment due only as each phase completes, and visible progress they can walk out and check.	A payment per completed phase	Each phase visibly done. Anything found underground stops the work: photograph it, show it, price it, get a signature, then carry on.
10 Substantial completion	Finished project walked together. Everything not right goes on a written punch list, both parties holding a copy.	The punch list, and ten business days for it to be cleared.	Nothing yet	The list is clear. The job is complete when the list is, not before, which is where the incentive belongs.
11 Closeout	Package handed over: plan copy, plant list, irrigation zone map with programmed settings, care guide, written warranty, and the maintenance proposal.	Everything a good gardener would need, whoever ends up holding the hose, plus an actual maintenance proposal with a cadence and a price.	Final payment	Maintenance offered at handover, as an offer and not a condition. The project price does not depend on the answer.
12 Follow-up	A call at thirty days, and again at six months.	Somebody to tell when a thing shows up that only living with the work reveals.	Nothing	Referrals and maintenance conversions come from here more cheaply than from anywhere else.

Change orders: the honest version of the same idea

A change order is the pipeline's pricing logic applied mid-build. New scope means a new number, written and signed before the work rather than discovered on an invoice. Three causes, and two of them are avoidable at bid time: scope the client adds, decisions made late, and genuine unknowns underground.

Which is why the exclusions page is the most valuable page in the document. Naming an exclusion tells the client exactly where their price ends, and lets them decide what to do about it: bring the item in now, price it separately, or accept the risk knowingly.

When the range comes back over their budget

That is the planning budget doing its job: it found the gap while closing it was still cheap. Three levers, in the order they usually work.

- **Material tier.** The biggest single lever on most projects. The same design in a different surface is a different price.
- **Scope.** Take something out or make it smaller. Planting instead of a hard surface.
- **Phasing.** Everything drawn on one plan at the start, the order set so the property is not built twice. Grading, drainage and anything running under paving goes first.

The fourth lever, quietly thinning base depth, drainage or soil preparation, is not available. It makes the job cheaper on paper and dearer in a few years, and the client pays that second bill.

05 THE OTHER SERVICE LINE

Seven stages, and it renews instead of ending

Priced separately, under its own agreement, and not a smaller version of a build. The pricing question is different: not *what does this project cost* but *what does this property take to keep, every visit, for a year*.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	THE PRICING MOVE	WHY IT IS THERE
01 Inquiry	Referral, build handover or search, recorded in the same place as build leads rather than in somebody's phone.	No number.	One inbox, or leads die quietly in three of them.
02 Route-fit screen	Address checked against the existing route days before anybody quotes or drives out. Openings are specific days, not any day.	The screen happens before pricing, not after	An off-route stop costs far more than it looks like it does, and the cost is drive time between stops. Clustering is the only lever there is.
03 Property walk and quote	Property walked: how much lawn, how much planted bed, a year of pruning, how much green waste comes off it, how easily equipment moves.	One set price per visit	A price from a photo or from the street is a price for a property nobody has seen. It changes the moment somebody walks it.
04 Service agreement	Written agreement: visit scope, cadence, service day, price, what is in, what is out, notice period, and the annual review on its face.	The set price, and everything outside it named	Month to month, thirty days' notice either side, no term to buy out. A standing obligation needs terms a construction contract lacks.
05 Onboarding visit	First visit is an assessment rather than a normal stop: photos, baseline condition, irrigation walked zone by zone.	No change to the price	Sets the record everything after is measured against, including any argument about what was already broken.
06 Route	Fixed day, same crew, weekly or biweekly, working from a standing list for that property rather than whatever catches the eye.	Price does not move because one visit ran long	Two things sit outside the set price: work that is not routine care, and materials brought for the client. Both priced and approved first.
07 Annual review	One fixed month a year, every account: is the scope still right, price re-struck, agreement renewed.	The price is re-struck once a year	A price that never changes on paper changes somewhere else instead, usually in how much time the property actually gets.

Cadence is a pricing conversation

Weekly for lawn, a lot of planted bed, or a client who wants the place tidy every day. Every other week for established shrubs, groundcover, gravel and decomposed granite. The honest test is the growing season: a lawn on a two-week cycle in late spring stops being maintained and starts being caught up. Changing cadence changes the agreement and the price, so it goes in writing.

Where the two lines meet

Build to maintenance. Offered at handover with an actual cadence and price, not a vague pitch. The first year decides whether a planting establishes, and the crew that built it knows where every valve, drain and root ball is.

Maintenance to build. Runs the full pipeline, no shortcuts. Being a maintenance client changes what GMZ already knows about the property, which sharpens the concept. It does not change how the work is priced, and the two agreements stay separate: neither absorbs the other.

06 THE ONE DECISION MADE BEFORE ANYTHING IS PRICED

Which pipeline is this lead even in?

Decided once, on the first call, and everything downstream follows from it. Get it wrong and either a build crew is sent to do an hour of work, or an hour of work is priced like a project.

ROUTE IT HERE	WHEN	FIRST NUMBER THE CLIENT HEARS	THEN
Design and build	Work that suits a build crew: planting, irrigation, drainage, patios, walls, fences, lighting. Scope described and budget band in the same neighbourhood.	A planning range, after a paid concept phase	Twelve stages. Free visit, paid concept, paid design, then a fixed price.
Build to others' plans	Client arrives with a complete set from an architect or designer, plus plant list and any grading, drainage and construction details.	A fixed price, after the drawings are checked against the ground. No design fee.	Skips stages 04 and 05. Say plainly where a plan will not work as drawn, and propose a fix.
Maintenance account	Ongoing routine care wanted, and the property sits near an existing route day. Openings are specific days.	One set price per visit, after a property walk	Seven stages. Own agreement, own schedule, own terms. Month to month.
One-off service call	Too small to mobilise a build crew: an afternoon of pruning, a repair, a small refresh, a one-time cleanup or a short run of catch-up visits.	A price for that visit	Route permitting. Plenty of cleanups become standing accounts once the reset is done, so quote both.
Decline, on the call	Budget band and scope are not in the same neighbourhood, the property is well off any route, or a hard date cannot honestly be met.	A straight answer, and the reason	Said before the drive, not after. An account GMZ would chronically reach late serves nobody.

Why the budget question is asked early, and out loud
It is the qualification gate, and it is asked as much for the client's benefit as for GMZ's: it is how they find out whether GMZ is in the right range, rather than finding out after a design is underway. A refusal to state a band is information too, and at small scopes, genuinely not knowing is fine. Record the band internally: the website says the town, never the number.

Never ask a client to prescribe the work

The intake form asks what they want the space to be like and how they want to use it, not what should be built. A client invited to specify the solution has to be walked back from it later, and that conversation costs more than the one it avoided. Ask for the problem: standing water, dead lawn, no privacy, an unusable slope, nowhere to sit. The solution is what the paid stages are for.

What the visit has to come back with, or stage 04 cannot be written

OFF THE PROPERTY

- **Whether it was measured or estimated by eye.** A measured take-off is what earns a firm number.
- Soil, grade, existing irrigation and drainage, and where water currently goes.
- Access: the narrowest gate, whether a small machine passes, and the carry distance.
- Photos: wide shots, the problem areas, the access route, the meter and the controller.
- Hours and miles spent on the lead so far.

ASKED OF THE CLIENT BEFOREHAND

- Photos of the whole area from several angles, including the parts they are unhappy with.
- A plot plan or survey, any architect's or designer's drawings, and the HOA rules that apply.
- How a truck and a small machine would reach the work area, and the narrowest gate width.
- Whether water collects anywhere after rain.
- What they want kept, and what is decided as against what is still open.
- None of it is required. It is the difference between one visit and two.

07 THE FAILURE MODES, ALL OF THEM CHEAP TO AVOID

Six things that undo the whole pipeline in one sentence

- **A number over the phone.** It becomes the figure the client remembers for the rest of the project, so every later and better number reads as a price increase.
- **A starting-at figure, anywhere.** Same reason, published. A number attached to nothing, and the first thing quoted back.
- **“The design fee comes off the construction price.”** It does not, and it is not refunded. Plenty of clients assume otherwise, and signing is the worst possible moment to find out.
- **“No problem, we can do that.”** Said on site, about something outside scope, without paper. Not generosity: a bill the client has not seen yet.
- **A padded allowance instead of a named exclusion.** It charges every client for the unlucky ones, and hides how much of the price was real work.
- **A start date without a signed contract.** The queue is held by paperwork. Say so plainly rather than let the client discover it in week six.

08 BEFORE ANY NUMBER LEAVES THE BUILDING

The internal check, and what this document deliberately does not say

Every number crosses the floor first
Whatever produced a number, a take-off, a change order, a maintenance quote or a re-struck annual price, it is checked against the per-day minimum for its service line before a client sees it. Below that, a job does not cover labour, overhead and profit. The two service lines have different minimums and the maintenance one is higher, so route work is checked against the maintenance book rather than the default.

Under it, there are three ways out and only three: add days, cut scope, or hold the price and walk away.

The numbers are not printed here on purpose
The per-day minimums and the rates behind them live in one place, Jeff's facts sheet, and are read from there every time. Printing them into an explainer creates a second home for a fact that changes, and the two drift apart within a month. That failure has been paid for once already at GMZ: a crew size written in twenty-three places, one of them still wrong.

Same reason this document names no phone number, no licence number and no address.

09 IF SOMETHING IN HERE NEEDS CHANGING

Where each kind of fact actually lives

THE FACT	ITS ONE HOME	WHY THERE AND NOWHERE ELSE
The stages themselves, and what each is for	docs/process-proposal.html	The stage model. If a stage moves, it moves there first, then here.
What may be said to a client at a stage	src/content/faqs , published entries	A published answer is settled policy. An unpublished one is a decision not yet made, and it shows on the site with its note attached rather than as a promise.
The intake questions and the compliance gates	docs/intake-forms.html	Both sides of the lead, the three gates, and the five items that stop a firm number.
Per-day minimums, rates, crew, route days	Jeff's facts sheet	Never retyped anywhere, including into this document. Ask Jeff, who reads it fresh.
Phone numbers, address, licence number, tagline	src/data/site.ts	One home on purpose. Correcting one copy of three leaves two of them wrong.

This document explains those sources. It is not one of them. Re-render it after any of them changes: `node scripts/render-pdf.mjs docs/pipeline-and-pricing.html`

10 STILL OPEN

Decisions that change what can be said at a stage

Each of these is a sentence GMZ cannot yet say. A client who asks gets “it is being finalised” instead of an answer, which is worse the further down it happens.

STAGE	THE OPEN QUESTION	WHAT IS BEING SAID IN THE MEANTIME
05	Who owns the drawings, and what copyright GMZ retains.	Nothing published. The recommended position is that the client receives the drawings and may use them for their property while GMZ keeps copyright. It has to match whatever is decided about taking them elsewhere.
05	Whether a client may take paid-for drawings to another contractor, and on what conditions.	Held back. Sensitive, and it must be consistent with the ownership clause in the design agreement.
11	The closeout package itself.	Three published answers promise a plan copy, plant list, irrigation zone map with settings and a care guide. No document delivers that yet. Either the template gets written, or the promise comes out of all three answers together.
07	The written workmanship warranty.	Half a page: one year on workmanship from completion, plants excluded and the reason stated. Named in the closeout package and not yet written.
03	The travel charge for a visit outside the towns served.	Written and held. Free inside the served towns; outside, a charge quoted before the drive. The amount and the outer limit are unset.
02	The minimum on a one-off service call.	Written and held. Solo visits are settled as an administrative task, not a field one. Needs the two minimums, and the line between one person alone and a truck.
—	What insurance language may be published.	Only the licence record is confirmed, so the site says that plus a certificate on request. No coverage sentence goes back up until the carrier and status are confirmed.

The rule all seven follow

An undecided policy does not get published, because a client will hold GMZ to whatever it said. A warranty term, a lead time or a fee nobody has agreed to is worse than silence: it is a promise made by accident. A testimonial is gated the same way.

`npm run faq:decisions` prints what is currently outstanding, with the note attached to each.

11 STAGE 02, ON ONE CARD

The first call, in the order to ask it

Not a new script: the list the site already tells clients to expect, in its own order. Fifteen minutes, and the last question is the gate.

- What do you want done?** The problem, not the solution. Standing water, dead lawn, no privacy, nowhere to sit.
- Where is the property?** Town first. It decides route fit and whether GMZ serves it at all.
- When would you like it done?** Ask what the date is attached to: an event, a house sale, a permit clock, a school year.
- Who else is part of the decision?** Partner, family, HOA board, property manager. Ask whether they will be at the visit.
- What range are you planning around?** The gate. Asked plainly, and asked for their benefit as much as GMZ's.

Then one of four things happens

- The band and the scope agree: **book the visit**, and give a real date.
- Too small for a build crew: **route it** to a service call or a maintenance stop. It does not get refused.
- Off-route maintenance, or a hard date that cannot be met: **say so on the call**.
- They press for a number: **the visit is free, the number comes after it**. No figure, not even a rough one.